

Hyperraising is less constrained than previously thought: New evidence from English

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0 Overview

- In this presentation I will show that colloquial English does have a form of hyperraising, despite the current consensus in the hyperraising literature (Zyman 2023). This provides a welcome way forward for unifying theories of A-movement across languages, and a number of unique properties of English hyperraising provide novel insight into several debated properties of hyperraising.
- The presentation is organized as follows:
 - Section 1 gives a brief overview of previous literature on hyperraising and its availability across different languages.
 - Section 2 introduces a previously underappreciated construction in English consisting of sentences like *Mei it seems is happy*, which I argue are cases of hyperraising.
 - In section 3, I discuss several interesting thematic properties of the English hyperraising construction and use them to explain the obligatoriness of *it* in *Mei it seems is happy*.
 - In section 4, I zero in on the locality profile of English hyperraising and argue that it is best analyzed as a composite A/ $\bar{A}$ construction. I also provide a derivation and a tree for the construction.
 - Finally, section 5 concludes.

1 Background

- Hyperraising, or raising out of a finite CP, is generally assumed to be illicit in English on the basis of the following contrast between (1) and (2):
 - (1) Mei seems [_{TP} Mei to be happy].
 - (2) *Mei seems [_{CP} (that) Mei is happy].
- The standard story: the Activity Condition, and/or a conspiracy of the Ban on Improper Movement + PIC, rules out hyperraising in languages:
 - **Activity** (Chomsky 2001) says that successful case assignment renders an argument inactive for further A-relations
 - The **Phase Impenetrability Condition** (Chomsky 2000) forces movement out of CP to proceed through Spec,CP, but the **Ban on Improper Movement** says that you can't move from an $\bar{A}$ position (assumed to include Spec,CP) to an A position (e.g. the final landing site of a hyperraised subject).
 - * Together, this means: if you're an argument that wants to escape a CP, you better be $\bar{A}$ -moving!
- Raising across CP boundaries nonetheless appears to be possible in many languages, which forces us to either tweak the conditions listed above or find language-specific reasons for hyperraising to be able to circumvent these conditions.
- A few representative examples:
 - **Brazilian Portuguese** (Nunes 2008): Hyperraising-to-subject is possible because there are ϕ -defective TPs in BP. These do not assign Case (no Activity violation), and they also render the CP containing them phasally 'defective' (no PIC violation).
 - **Mongolian** (Fong 2019): Hyperraising-to-object is possible in Mongolian because embedded Spec,CP in this language is an A-position (no BoIM violation).
 - **Zulu** (Halpert 2019): Argues that hyperraising is not mediated by the PIC or Activity, but Relativized Minimality. Hyperraising is possible in Zulu exactly when the embedded clause does not serve as a ϕ /EPP intervener.
 - **Cantonese & Vietnamese** (Lee and Yip 2024): Hyperraising is subject to the PIC (and BoIM), but the CP phase can be **unlocked**, i.e. rendered transparent for further A-operations, by an instance of Agree between matrix v and the embedded CP.

- Lohninger (2025): Hyperraising is a mixed A/ $\bar{A}$ phenomenon that involves a single probe that seeks both a goal bearing an A-feature (e.g. ϕ , D) **and** a goal bearing an $\bar{A}$ -feature. The intermediate movement step in hyperraising (Spec,TP $\rightarrow$ Spec,CP) is a special type of A-movement (or at least not strictly $\bar{A}$ -movement), and thus can feed subsequent matrix A-movement. Languages where C is endowed with an A/ $\bar{A}$ composite probe may thus allow hyperraising, but where C only has an $\bar{A}$ probe they will not.
- Regardless of what you take to be the key properties for licensing hyperraising, it's generally assumed that English lacks these.
- But in most cases, it's hard to actually find independent evidence that English genuinely does not meet the criteria to be a hyperraising language (i.e. beyond the assumed lack of hyperraising).
 - Is English T really **less** ϕ -impoverished than Brazilian Portuguese?
 - What lets Spec,CP be an A-position in Mongolian but not in English?
 - Why can C be endowed with a composite A/ $\bar{A}$ probe in hyperraising languages but not in English?
 - Why can v agree with and unlock CP in some Vietnamese and Cantonese, but not English?
- Halpert (2019) stands out for actually pinning down the locus of variation w.r.t. hyperraising on an independent property: the status of the embedded clause as an A-over-A intervener.
 - In English, CPs headed by *that* can satisfy the EPP and trigger ϕ -agreement:
 - (3) [_{CP} That he isn't home yet] is worrying.
 - (4) [_{CP} That he isn't home yet] and [_{CP} that he isn't answering his messages] **are** equally worrying.
 - In Zulu, finite CPs *cannot* satisfy the EPP.
 - Halpert's conclusion: hyperraising is ruled out in English because the embedded CP is an intervener, but ruled in in Zulu because CP is *not* an intervener.
 - Zyman (2023) points out an issue with this, which is that even speakers who don't accept (4) still do not allow hyperraising sentences like **Mei seems that is happy*. Furthermore, it's not clear that the A-over-A intervener story can be naturally extended to *that*-less CPs.
- To sum up so far: we don't have a great story on the market for why English lacks hyperraising. My contribution to this is to say **actually, English does have hyperraising**.

- This is nice for more than just theory-unification reasons. English hyperraising has a number of unique & salient properties that let us test the predictions of different theories of hyperraising and locality more broadly:
 - Does hyperraising respect the William's Cycle/Generalized Ban on Improper Movement? Answer from English: yes.
 - Does A-movement need to obey the θ -criterion? Answer from English: yes.
 - For any given string that looks like hyperraising, can we be sure it's not just copy-raising with *pro*-drop in the embedded clause? In English, yes.
 - Is hyperraising a mixed A/ $\bar{A}$ dependency? In English, yes.
 - Is hyperraising A-minimal? It's complicated, but not really (at least for English)! Please help. :)

2 English hyperraising

- I am going to argue that colloquial English allows for a form of hyperraising in sentences like the following:
 - (5) Mei it seems [_{CP} ~~Mei~~ is happy].
 - (6) **He** it seems [_{CP} ~~he~~ is being pitched as the moderately sane face of the Tory Party]. (web)
 - (7) This writer John it seems has what you might almost call an obsession with light and dark. (web; 7m25s mark)
- These sentences are characterized by:
 1. A displaced DP that appears at the beginning of the matrix clause and leaves a gap in the subject position of the embedded clause.
 2. Nominative case on the displaced DP (*cf.* 6).
 3. An instance of *it* after the displaced DP.
- Additionally, the most readily accepted examples involve an embedded clause lacking an overt complementizer. Examples like (8) are universally rejected:
 - (8) *Mei it seems that is happy.

- But for at least some speakers (including me) the embedded clause can be introduced by *like*, and more rarely *as though*. (I will stick to complementizer-less sentences for the rest of the handout).

- (9) So many people it seems [_{CP} like ~~so many people~~ are condemning the RF for something that they didn't have a part in].
(web)
- (10) And now **she** it sounds [_{CP} like ~~she~~ is deducing that maybe she meant a different case]. (web)
- (11) These people it seems [_{CP} as though ~~these people~~ have been eaten as we eat chicken]. (web)

2.1 This construction can't be written off as a parenthetical

- People's first-pass counteranalysis of (5–11) is usually to say that *it seems/appears* is a parenthetical inserted in the middle of a single TP like 'Mei is happy'.
- There *is* a possible parse of (5–2) where *it seems* is offset before and after by a pause and can be placed in various positions, including sentence-finally:

- (12) Mei, it seems, is happy.
- (13) Mei is happy, it seems.

- But this analysis fails to fully capture the construction. *It seems* may be accompanied matrix subject-bound NPIs (??-14), which unlike true parentheticals (Ross 1984) can't be sentence-final:

- (14) **Only he** (it **ever** seemed) was being pitched as the face of the party, (*it **ever** seemed).

- Note also that canonical parentheticals resist NPIs bound from outside the parenthetical:

- (15) Parentheticals and NPIs (Burton-Roberts 2005)
 - a. None of the authors who had (any) imagination remained.
 - b. None of the authors, who had (*any) imagination, remained.
- (16) Burton-Roberts's examples can be modified to use *only* DPs and *ever* and the same contrast holds:
- (17) Only the authors who (ever) used their imagination remained.

(18) Only the authors, who *(ever) used their imagination, remained.

- Additionally, parentheticals seem invisible to the rest of the clause for the sake of Principle B, while the experiencer in the proposed hyperraising construction is subject to Principle B:

(19) Mei_i , it seems to her_i , is in a lot of trouble.

(20) * Mei_i it seems to her_i is in a lot of trouble.

- Moving on from parentheticals, another possible non-hyperraising analysis is that sentences like *Mei it seems is happy* involve a base-generated topic in the left-periphery. However, base-generated topics in English bear default case, namely ACC (Parrott (2006), Radford (2018)), as in (21). By contrast, the raised DP in the hypothesized hyperraising construction bears NOM (22):

(21) Him/*he, he's a great guy.

(22) He/*him it seems is being pitched as the moderately sane face of the Tory Party.

2.2 This construction involves movement

- I now turn to positive evidence in favor of a movement analysis for *Mei it seems is happy*. First, as exemplified below, the hypothesized moved DP *Mei* obeys islands¹:

(23) **Ed** it seems you think ~~Ed~~ is boring. (No island)

(24) ***Ed** it seems you wonders whether (despite what people say) ~~Ed~~ is boring. (*wh*-island)

(25) ***Ed** it seems Mei hates the way ~~Ed~~ is acting today. (Complex NP island)

- Second, the moved DP can strand quantifiers:

(26) The boys it seems **both** ~~the boys~~ went home.

(27) The kids it seems **all** ~~the kids~~ know what they're doing.

¹Yes, these sentences appear to violate Minimality! We'll return to that issue shortly.

2.3 This construction involves A movement

- To diagnose the movement of *Mei* in *Mei it seems as happy* as A-movement rather than A-bar movement, we make use of weak crossover and binding. Two diagnostics that favor an A-movement analysis include an absence of Weak Crossover (WCO) effects and the ability to feed new binding possibilities (Postal (1971), Wasow (1972), and much subsequent work; see Van Urk (2015), Lohninger (2025) for contemporary overviews).

2.3.1 Crossover, Binding

- WCO: the moved preverbal DP in the hypothesized hyperraising sentences is able to bind a pronoun that it “crosses over”, suggesting an absence of weak crossover effects in this construction.

(28) Every dad_i it seems to his_i kids ~~every dad~~ is terrible at telling jokes.

(29) Most dogs_i it seems to their_i owners ~~most dogs~~ are extremely cute.

- Similar facts hold for strong crossover:

(30) Mary_i it seems to herself_i is a genius.

- Binding: The principle C facts also favor an A-movement analysis.
- In (31) where *Mei's father* remains *in situ*, the sentence is ungrammatical, presumably due to a principle C violation induced by *(to) her* c-commanding the coindexed R-expression *Mei*.

(31) *It seems to **her**_i (that) **Mei**_i's **father** is a real jerk.

(32) It seems to her_i that the picture of Mei_i is ugly.

- But when the R-expression is moved as in (33) such that *Mei_i* is no longer c-commanded by *her_i*, the resulting sentences are perfectly acceptable, suggesting obviation of principle C.

(33) **Mei**_i's **father** it seems to **her**_i is a real jerk.

(34) The picture of Mei_i it seems to her_i is ugly.

Given the previous diagnostics, our interim conclusion is as follows: we're dealing with movement of the subject from the embedded CP to the matrix clause, and this movement acts like A-movement.

2.3.2 Intervention effects (or at least a subject/object asymmetry)

- If this construction is (strictly) A-movement, we would expect that moved DPs in our proposed hyperraising construction cannot be objects, since the presence of an intervening subject would cause a Minimality violation.
- But the evidence regarding object displacement effects is less clear, because we can't use case-marking to distinguish between an A-moved embedded object and a hanging topic base generated in the left periphery as we could with subjects.
- The string in (36) is in principle compatible with either an A-movement or $\bar{A}$ -topic analysis:

(35) She it seems ~~she~~ has hit him. (Closest embedded subject)

(36) Him ?(,) it seems Mei has hit ~~him~~. (embedded object)

- What we need to do is test these cases of object displacement against the same diagnostics used to justify an A-movement analysis of *Mei it seems is happy*
- What we find is that object displacement does *not* obviate WCO or principle C violations:

(37) *Every father_i(,) it seems to his_i kids (that) most people like ~~every father~~.

(38) *Most dogs_i(,) it seems to their_i owners (that) other dogs love.

- Also unlike A-movement, cross-clausal object movement cannot obviate a principle C violation (39).

(39) *Mei's father(,) it seems to her_i other people dislike.

- Finally, idiom preservation suggests that object displacement may not actually involve genuine movement of the object (e.g., it may involve operator movement and a base-generated hanging topic):

(40) # The fan(,) it seems the shit has hit.

(41) # The bag(,) it seems the cat is out of.

(42) # The bucket(,) it seems Ali kicked. (on idiomatic reading)

(43) # The dust(,) it seems Ali is biting.

(44) # The hay(,) it seems Ali is about to hit.

(45) # The ice(,) it seems the students are about to break.

- This contrasts with the subject idioms, which do retain an idiomatic reading, suggesting the subject starts out in the embedded clause:

(46) The shit it seems has hit the fan.

(47) The cat it seems is out of the bag.

(48) That ship it seems has sailed.

(49) The die it seems has been cast.

(50) ?The bucket it seems has been kicked.

2.4 Summing up: properties of the hypothesized hyperraising construction

- DP displacement across *it seems . . .* bears the following characteristics:
 - Shows case continuity effects
 - Preserves subject idioms
 - Shows island effects
 - Strands quantifiers
 - Obviates WCO
 - Creates new binding configurations
 - Is possible for subjects, but not objects

3 *It* and the role of the θ -criterion

- A puzzling property of English hyperraising is the obligatory presence of *it* between the raised DP and raising verb, as in *Mei*
*(*it*) *seems is a genius*; essentially, hyperraising in English gives rise to a double subject construction.

- Interestingly, hyperraising as a double subject construction has recently been independently argued for in Tiriki (Johnson and Diercks 2024).
- My explanation for this has three parts: first, I argue that this intervening *it* is actually referential and denotes a P(erceptual)-source. Second, I argue that *seems* has a P-SOURCE θ -role to assign when it embeds a CP. Finally, I assume that movement between θ -positions is illicit.

3.1 *It* is referential

- R-*it* can occur with the control verb *want* (51) and can be quantified (52); contrast this with expletive *there* (54):

- (51) *Looking in mirror: It* almost wants to seem like a few pounds came off. (web)
- (52) I have the same feeling towards [Andrew] Tate.. remember when he says he is the first angel and the last man? Entrusted by God? All knowing? **It all** seems like he is trying to be a new prophet. (web))
- (53) He left the royal family by choice. Now **it all** seems $\emptyset_C$ he wants to feel relevant again. (web)
- (54) a. ***There** wanted to arrive plenty of people.
b. ***There all** arrived plenty of people.

3.2 CP-embedding *seems* has a θ -role to assign its external argument

- Now we're faced with the question of why a referential *it* is necessary with hyperraising/CP-embedding *seems* but ruled out in ordinary raising/TP-embedding *seems*:

(55) a. John (*it) seems to be happy. (ordinary raising)
b. John *(it) seems is happy. (hyperraising)
- I argue that the presence of R-*it* in hyperraising sentences is required in order to absorb a P(ERCEPTUAL)-SOURCE θ -role assigned by CP-embedding *seems* to its external argument.
- Otherwise, the raised subject (e.g. *Mei*) is forced passes through two θ positions, which I assume to be ruled out under the θ -criterion.
- I will also show that TP-embedding *seems* does not assign such a θ -role.

- First, consider the fact that CP-embedding *seems* alternates with sensory perception verbs, while TP-embedding *seems* does not:

(56) It {seems / sounds / smells / feels} like John is here. (CP-*seems*)

(57) John {seems / *sounds / *smells / *feels} to be here. (TP-*seems*)

- Second, consider the contrast below, adapted from Rudolph (2019). Imagine Ed is not in his kitchen, but you see pots and pans are on the stove with food simmering in them. You may felicitously utter (58, but not (59):

(58) Tom seems [_{TP} to be cooking].

(59) # Tom seems [_{CP} (like/as though) he's cooking]. (Rudolph (2019))

- This suggests that while CP-embedding *seems* imposes a P-SOURCE thematic requirement on its subject, TP-embedding *seems* does not.

- An aside: there is some controversy about whether the contrast just reported always holds; Landau (2011) and Heycock (1993) both purport to show counterexamples.

(60) Here's the grade sheet: Oh, John looks like he has failed the exam. Landau (2011)

(61) (In response to a report about someone else's car) Your car sounds like it needs tuning very badly. Heycock (1993)

- But as Asudeh and Tovoinen (2017) discuss, these sentences are still compatible with a P-SOURCE interpretation:

- * The mention of the car (as in (61)) or the appearance of John's name on the grade sheet (as in (60)) serve as proxies for the car itself and John himself, respectively

- * This matches my intuition that not just any hearsay can license (61) and not just any gradesheet can license (60).

- I find (60) infelicitous in a context where the observed gradesheet simply reports a class average, although one can confidently infer that John failed if the class average on the sheet is 0%; it must be the case that John's name and grade appear and are directly observed.

- Additionally, experimental work by Rett et al. (2013) replicates the contrast reported by Rudolph (2019) and others. Sentences like “Milo seems like he visited the pig farm” were uniformly rejected by participants (i.e. rated ‘weird’) when they were given a context that was incompatible with direct perception of the referent Milo.

3.3 Recap: Hyperraising over *it seems* and the θ -criterion

- Hyperraising in English requires an *it*_{P-SOURCE} because the CP-embedding verb *seems* has a P-SOURCE θ -role to assign.
- If *it* is not externally merged to absorb this θ -role, either (a) the P-SOURCE θ -role goes unassigned, in violation of the θ -criterion (and see Collins 2024 for empirical arguments in favor of this particular constraint), or (b) The hyperraised DP gets two θ -roles, also in violation of the θ -criterion.
- Note: If you *do* want to ensure that referent denoted by the embedded DP is interpreted as a P-SOURCE, you must use a copy-raising construction, which involves two externally merged arguments for two θ -roles:

(62) **Mei**_{*i*} seems like **she**_{*i*} is happy.

- Of course the presence of *it* raises another issue, namely one of Minimality.

4 Revisiting Minimality: Hyperraising as a mixed A/ $\bar{A}$ construction

- While the English hyperraising construction is definitely movement and bears the anti-reconstruction & binding signatures of A-movement, we have already seen a few $\bar{A}$ -esque properties.
- First, movement to the matrix clause is optional in (63) but obligatory in canonical clause-bound raising in (64).

- (63) a. It seems Mei is happy.
b. Mei it seems ~~Mei~~ is happy.

- (64) a. *(It/there/ $\emptyset_{expl}$) seems Mei to be happy.
b. Mei seems ~~Mei~~ to be happy.

- Second, we've seen that the moved DP can bypass an intervening *it*, or even another (less) embedded subject, also unlike ordinary raising:

(65) **Mei** it seems **you** think ~~Mei~~ is crazy.

(Hyperraising)

(66) ***Hasan** seem(s) **you** to like ~~Hasan~~.

(Ordinary raising)

- Third, English hyperraising constructions have a clear connection to information structure.
- HR is compatible with either a topic-comment configuration (67), or a (e.g. contrastive) focus configuration (68).
- They are infelicitous in out-of-the-blue/neutral contexts (69), unlike canonical/clause-bound raising (70).

(67) A: What does Mei do again?

B: Mei_{TOP} it seems is going back to school to study medicine.

(68) Of our recent graduates, Hasan_{FOC} is working as a nurse while Mei_{FOC} it would seem has gone back to school to study medicine.

(69) # Mei it seems is going home.

(Out of the blue, HR)

(70) Mei seems to be going home.

(Out of the blue, ordinary R)

- Finally, HR in English is incompatible with additional $\bar{A}$ -dependencies like object topicalization and *wh*-movement.
- Lohninger and Yip 2023 in particular posit that cross-clausal dependencies that involve conjunctive probing for A and $\bar{A}$ features should bleed further $\bar{A}$ extraction.
- In their analysis, in languages where C probes simultaneously for a goal that bears both an A feature (e.g. D) and an $\bar{A}$ feature (e.g. TOPIC), said probing should halt further $\bar{A}$ -probing.
- Interestingly, we see evidence for such effects in English.
- While ordinary (e.g. i.e. strictly A-movement) raising may combine with *wh*-extraction and object topicalization, hyperraising allows neither:

(71) Ordinary raising

a. Mei seems to have hit him.

b. Who(m) does Mei seem to have hit ~~who(m)~~?

(*wh*-extraction)

c. Him, Mei seems to have hit ~~him~~.

(topicalization)

(72) Embedded subject *in situ* under raising *it*

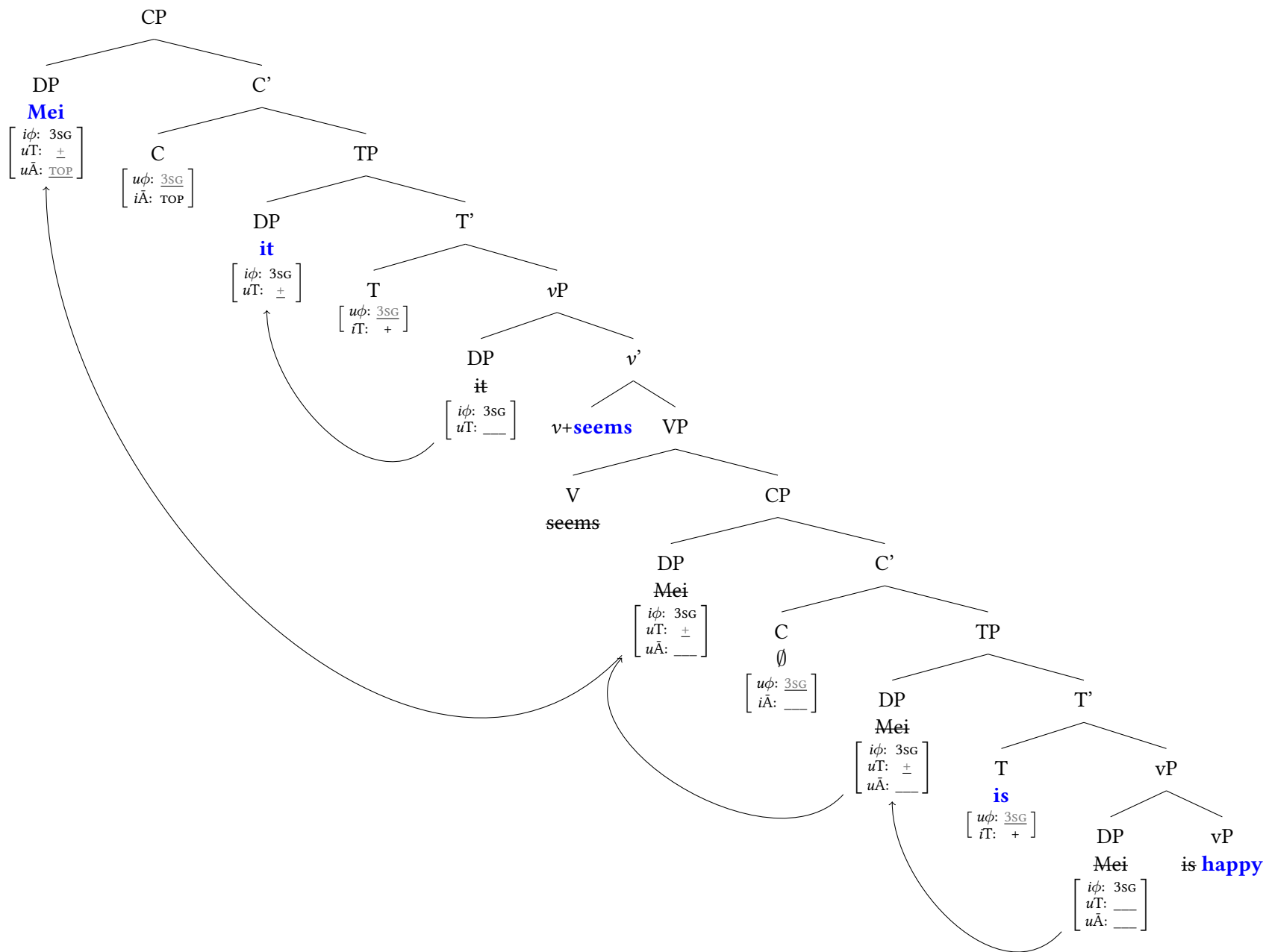
a. It seems Mei has hit him.

- b. Who(m) does it seem Mei has hit ~~who(m)~~? (wh-extraction)
 - c. Him, it seems Mei has hit ~~him~~. (topicalization)
- (73) Hyperraising over raising *it*
 - a. Mei it seems has hit him.
 - b. *Who does Mei it seem has hit ~~who~~? (wh-extraction)
 - c. *Him, Mei it seems has hit ~~him~~. (topicalization)
- If English HR involves composite A/ $\bar{A}$ probing as these data all suggest, then Minimality, the Phase Impenetrability Condition, and the Ban on Improper Movement are not threatened by my analysis:
 - The PIC can be skirted by movement through the edge of CP, which wouldn't violate the Ban on Improper Movement if said movement is both A and A' movement.
 - There need not be a Relativized Minimality violation caused by the presence of an intervening DP; the composite probe doesn't see non-topic DPs as potential goals.

4.1 A tree and a derivation

- We're finally in a place where we can derive and draw a tree for the English hyperraising construction.
- I assume Agree is checked via upward probing à la Bjorkman and Zeijlstra (2019), and that movement in order to undergo further Agree operations may be parasitic on a previous instance of successful upward Agree.
 - A welcome consequence of this analysis is that there is no need for positing EPP features to drive movement; movement is driving by the need to check remaining unvalued uninterpretable features on some head.
 - The fact that *Mei* is allowed to make a long-distance move to Spec,CP is allowed by the fact that *Mei* is the only nominal made accessible to C in the course of the derivation by virtue of its TOP feature that enters into Agree with C.
- I also assume a view of successive cyclic movement driven by Relativized Minimality, following Abels (2003) and Halpert and Zeijlstra (2024);
 - Embedded C, the intermediate landing site for the hyperraised DP, also bears an $\bar{A}$ feature, albeit an unvalued/default one.

- Because this embedded C constitutes a closer goal bearing the $\bar{A}$ feature that the raised DP is trying to Agree with, the raised DP must stop in embedded Spec,CP.
 - But because its $\bar{A}$ feature is still unvalued, the raised DP keeps searching and ultimately moves to its final landing site which bears a valued $\bar{A}$ -feature.
- Finally, I assume a version of Pesetsky & Torrego's (2007) view of nominative case assignment wherein the argument in Spec,TP has uT feature that is valued by finite T.



- An abbreviated derivation for *Mei it seems is happy* (starting with the embedded VP already assembled):
 1. v is externally merged above the embedded VP. It has a THEME θ -role to assign its external argument.
 2. *Mei* is externally merged in Spec,vP of the embedded clause. It bears one valued, interpretable feature: [$i\phi$: [3SG]]. It bears two unvalued, uninterpretable features: [uT : []], corresponding to Case, and [$u\bar{A}$: []].
 3. v assigns the θ -role THEME to *Mei*.
 4. Embedded T bearing [$u\phi$: []] and [iT : [+]] merged above vP.
 5. Unvalued [uT : []] on *Mei* probes upward for a goal bearing valued [T] and finds *T* bearing [iT : [+]], yielding [uT : [+]] on *Mei*.
 6. ϕ on T remains unchecked, and since ϕ -bearing *Mei* is now accessible to T due to the previous instance of Agree, *Mei* moves to Spec,TP to check $u\phi$ on T.
 7. T probes upwards and, finding $i\phi$ on *Mei*, copies the value 3SG.
 8. Embedded C bearing [$i\bar{A}$: [TOP]] and [$u\phi$: []] is merged above TP.
 9. *Mei* probes upward for a goal bearing an $\bar{A}$ feature and finds embedded C, then Agrees with it and copies its value (vacuously).
 10. $u\phi$ on embedded C is still unchecked, but due to the previous instance of Agree between *Mei* and embedded C, *Mei* is still accessible to C and moves to Spec,CP to check $u\phi$.
 11. The matrix V *seems* is merged above CP.
 12. v is merged above VP. It has a P-SOURCE θ -role to assign its external argument.
 13. *it* bearing [$i\phi$: [3SG]] and [uT : []] is externally merged in Spec,vP.
 14. Matrix v assigns the θ -role P-SOURCE to *it*.
 15. Matrix T bearing [$u\phi$: []] and [iT : [+]] is merged above vP.
 16. *it* probes upward for an iT -bearing goal and, finding T, copies the value [+].
 17. $u\phi$ on T remains unvalued, but due to the previous instance of Agree, *it* is accessible to T and moves to Spec,TP in order to check $u\phi$.
 18. T probes upwards for a ϕ goal and, finding *it*, copies the value 3SG.
 19. Matrix C bearing [$i\bar{A}$: [TOP]] and [$u\phi$: []] is merged above TP.

20. *Mei* probes upward for a goal bearing a valued $\bar{A}$ feature and finds matrix C, then Agrees with it and copies its value.
 21. $u\phi$ on C is still unchecked, but due to the previous instance of Agree between *Mei* and matrix C, *Mei* is accessible to C and moves to Spec,CP to check $u\phi$.
 22. C Agrees with *Mei* and copies the value 3sg.
 23. The derivation converges.
- One nice thing about this derivation is that it obeys the Williams Cycle.
 - The Williams Cycle (Williams (2003)) says that movement from or across YP to a position X is banned if X is lower than YP in the functional sequence.
 - This rules out hyperraising to Spec,TP, but not HR to Spec,CP.
 - Another really nice thing is that this derivation is very similar to the proposed derivation for non-agreeing hyperraising in Tiriki in Johnson and Diercks (2024):

(74) Va-ana *pro*_{EVIDENCE} ka-loloekh-a khuli va-tukh-i.
 2-child *pro*_{EVIDENCE} 6SM-seem-FV that 2SM-arrive-FV.
 “The children seem to have arrived.”
 - Finally, Halpert (2019) & Halpert and Zeijlstra (2024)’s A-over-A minimality account of embedded clause opacity in HR languages makes the right prediction for English: only *that*-headed (& maybe *if*-headed) CPs compete for subject position, and these are exactly the CPs that *cannot* be hyperraised out of in English. (Though there is a confound—these could be COMP-trace effects.)
 - A not-so-nice thing is that I’ve overcorrected a bit w.r.t. Minimality, and now it seems like we should let *any* DP with an appropriate $\bar{A}$ -feature hyperraise, not just subjects.
 - But we only want objects to be able to hyperraise given the data in section 1.
 - This tension—namely, allowing some Minimality violations but not allowing objects to raise over subjects—also applies to Brazilian Portuguese, where only subjects can hyperraise, but they can hyperraise out of CPs that are themselves possible goals for ϕ -agreement and the EPP (Greson (2024)).
 - It also arises in any analysis that assumes hyperraising is a composite A/ $\bar{A}$ phenomenon, e.g. Lohninger et al. (2022), Lohninger and Yip (2023), and Lohninger (2025).

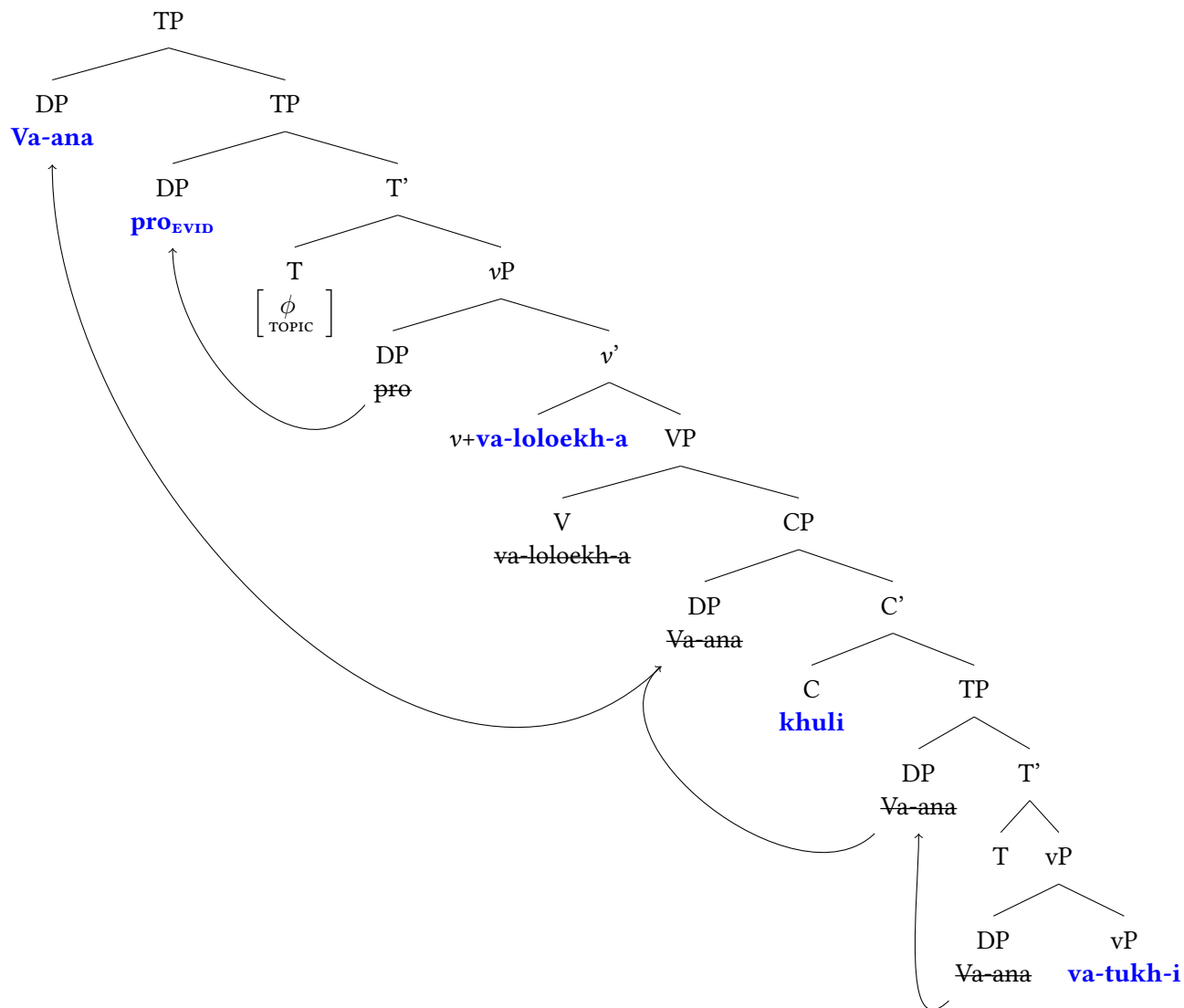


Figure 1: A tree for *The children it seems have arrived* in Tiriki, from Johnson and Diercks (2024).

- Lohninger (2025) notes this, and suggests that the impossibility of object-to-subject hyperraising in HR languages is due to a VoiceP/vP phase boundary.

5 Discussion

- I have argued that HR is attested in English—it simply looks different than we might have expected.
- I exploited asymmetries between TP-embedding *seems* and CP-embedding *seems* to argue that the real barrier to hyperraising in English is the θ -criterion. To this end I also showed that *it* that occurs with CP-embedding *seems* is not a true expletive, but rather a referential argument, which I propose absorbs the θ -role assigned by *seems*.
- I also showed that we can get a lot of mileage out of the θ -criterion when we look where (hyper)raising is and is not licensed cross-linguistically with different types of perception verbs.
- There are a lot of questions I would still like to answer, though:
 1. Is there a robust connection between the size of complement clauses a (raising) verb takes and the thematic properties of that verb?
 2. I.e. is it merely a quirk of English that CP-embedding *seems* behaves like a lexical perception verb while TP-embedding *seems* acts more like an epistemic modal?
 3. When we consider HR constructions like the one I highlight here, is hyperraising actually that rare? It would be good to look at other non-*pro*-drop languages, since they wear their movement gaps on their sleeve.
 4. Is there a way to account for the subject/object asymmetry + general lack of A-Minimality *without* invoking vP phasehood?
 5. Is there a way to use something like the θ -criterion without fully ruling out all cases of movement between θ -positions? (I think so; ask me about it if you want!)
 6. Is there a deep connection between height of a raising verb and its thematic properties? If so, the CP/TP asymmetry observed for raising in various languages (incl. English, formerly) may be less about locality and more about the thematic properties of the raising verb in question.
 7. My account predicts that HR *without* and *it* should be possible if we can find a genuinely athematic predicate to hyperraise over. This prediction appears partially borne out, at least for some speakers.

(75) %Gaps behind the cladding are thought [_{CP} <> may have created a chimney effect, drawing flames upward.] ([web](#))

- In a subsequent Twitter poll (where I changed ‘cladding’ to ‘outer wall’ but kept everything else the same), a minority of speakers accepted (75) [N=5 accept, N=10 ‘iffy’, N=15 reject] and similar attested sentences, but categorically rejected the same sentence where ‘are thought’ is replaced with ‘seem.’
8. What prediction do we make about parasitic gaps? They haven’t been found in other mixed A/ $\bar{A}$ dependencies (but mostly for lack of trying). I’ll leave you with this:
- Mei_i it seems some friends of tr_i think tr_i is a genius.

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